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IS212 (AY 2026-27, T1) – Week 2: User Story Assignment

Background

Last week, we received a (wordy!) briefing from the ‘customer’ about the system they want your group to implement for the IS212 project.

Before jumping into coding, it is important to build some consensus on *what exactly needs to be built*. To achieve this, we will be creating some **user story cards** (as introduced in this week’s class) to describe the features of the system desired by the customer.

These user story cards will be based on our **current understanding** of the system. In later weeks (i.e. after this assignment), you will be able to refine the user story cards further as the customer starts answering your questions and providing more details/context¹.

Tasks

The goal of this assignment is to seed your team’s product backlog with a set of high-quality user story cards, and to give you practice reviewing and refining stories against the INVEST criteria.

You will work in two stages. First, **generate** a pool of candidate user stories together as a (prospective) team. Then **divide and conquer**: each member takes three different stories from the pool to review and refine. The submission is individual — you submit the three cards you personally refined — but the generation and division of work are done collaboratively with your team.

You may use **AI tools** to help generate and refine your user story cards. However, you remain accountable for everything you submit: you should understand and be able to stand behind each card. Since these stories go on to seed your team’s product backlog for the project, aim for quality you can build on.

We suggest you conduct the exercise as follows:

- (1) As a (prospective) team, generate a pool of candidate user stories from the customer briefing. Aim for a generous pool — comfortably more than three per member — so

¹ Recall that agile practitioners favour “responding to change over following a plan”!

there is room to select and improve. (If you don't yet have a team, generate a pool on your own.)

- (2) Divide and conquer: agree who takes which stories, so that each member owns three different stories. This way your team collectively refines up to 15–18 distinct cards.
 - (3) Individually review and refine your three stories. Each finished card should consist of:
 - Title
 - User Story
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - *NB: you do not need to include a priority or estimate.*
 - (4) Ensure that each of your refined cards satisfies the INVEST criteria.
 - (5) Submit your three refined user story cards via the “User Story Assignment” quiz on **eLearn**.
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Submission & Deadline

You should individually submit the three user story cards you refined via the “User Story Assignment” quiz on eLearn. Submissions via email etc. will **NOT** be accepted.

This individual assignment is worth **2.5%** of the overall mark for IS212 and is graded **Pass / Fail**. A reasonable, good-faith submission that meets the requirements earns a **Pass** (full 2.5%); an invalid, incomplete, or nonsensical submission earns a **Fail** (0%). You can still Pass even if there are improvements to be made – that is what our formative feedback is for.

You must submit your cards to eLearn before 23:59 four days after your section's class.

There is a **penalty of 50% for late submission** (i.e. a passing submission earns 1.25% instead of 2.5%) up until 23:59 five days after your section's class. No submissions will be accepted beyond that.

Feedback: formative feedback will be provided on your submission to help you strengthen your stories before they seed the product backlog. AI tools may be used to help generate this feedback, but all feedback is reviewed and edited by an instructor before it is released to you.

Grading

This assignment is graded Pass / Fail:

Outcome	Criteria
Pass	• A genuine, good-faith attempt. • Submits three user story cards. • Each card follows the prescribed format (Title, User Story, Acceptance Criteria). • Reflects a reasonable attempt to satisfy the INVEST criteria.
Fail	• Invalid, empty, or nonsensical submission. • Fewer than three cards, or cards missing required elements. • Not a genuine attempt (e.g. placeholder or copied text unrelated to the briefing).

What a strong card looks like. Grading is Pass/Fail, but aim for cards you'd be happy to build on. Our formative feedback will focus on these qualities. A strong card:

- Follows the format: a clear Title, a User Story (e.g. "As a ... I want ... so that ..."), and testable Acceptance Criteria.
- Describes the desired functionality clearly and unambiguously.
- Satisfies INVEST: Independent, Negotiable, Valuable, Estimable, Small, Testable.